neighbors and with the Palestinians through bilateral negotiations with each party separately, usually (but not always) with the mediation or involvement of the United States; it has generally expressed reservations or even vehement opposition to negotiations with a pan-Arab coalition. Israel has taken this position for many reasons, though this is not the place to discuss them or to assess whether they were justified.

The bilateral approach has yielded two peace agreements thus far—one with Egypt, which was achieved with the intensive involvement of the United States in most stages of the negotiations, and the other with Jordan, which was attained without American involvement.

On the other hand, attempts to reach a peace agreement or longterm arrangement with the Palestinians, both those that were discussed bilaterally without the involvement of an outside party and those involving the United States, have thus far failed. The Oslo Accords did not live up to the hopes that were pinned on them, as even those who supported them will agree.

Some Arab thinkers have expressed the view that one of the main reasons for the protraction of the Israeli-Palestinian conflict has been the Arab states' desire to keep it "on a low flame" as a conceptual "glue" to unite the entire Arab nation. The notion of Pan-Arabism, which once served as a unifying "glue" for the Arab countries, dissolved over the years until it finally died in the 1991 Gulf War, when Arab states fought against their fellow Arab country of Iraq.

I argue that the Arab states, certainly the more moderate among them, are tired of the Israeli-Palestinian conflict, are interested in ending it, and see the Palestinians as the ones who have mounted obstacles and have adopted destructive approaches throughout the history of negotiations. To clarify this point, I will offer a few examples from my personal experience on this issue in meetings with Arab leaders during my tenure as director of the Mossad (1989 to 1996):

- In a three-person meeting with a certain Arab leader, whenever the subject of Arafat or the Palestinians came up, he would use words in Arabic that are not suitable for print.
- In a meeting with another leader, when I asked him how many Palestinians were in his country, he glared at me and said, "There are no Palestinians in my country, nor will there ever be."